Small Business Security + AI Starter Kit

Plain-English steps to protect your business and save time with AI.

Collar City Tech Help
Mail: PO Box 182, Waterford, NY 12188
collarcitytechhelp.com · collarcitytechhelp@gmail.com

Version 1.0 · Your purchase includes this kit for your business's own use. Please don't resell or share it.

1. Welcome: how to use this kit

Most small businesses are not hacked by movie-style geniuses. They lose money to a fake invoice, a reused password, a missing backup, or an employee who clicked the wrong link. The good news: a handful of simple habits stops most of it, and none of them cost much.

How to get the most from this kit

1. **Start with Section 2**, the one-page checklist. Print it and tick off what you already do.
2. **Fix the red items first.** Passwords, two-step login, and backups give the biggest safety gain for the least effort.
3. **Do one section a day.** Each takes 10 to 30 minutes. In two weeks you'll be far ahead of most small businesses.
4. **Share Section 10** (the staff one-pager) with everyone who touches a computer or phone for work.
5. **Use the AI prompts in Section 9** to save time on posts, replies, and reminders. Always read before you send.

> **What this kit is, and is not.** It is general guidance for small businesses. It is not legal advice, not a compliance certification, and not a guarantee. No service or checklist can promise you will never be hacked. The goal is to make you much harder to fool and much easier to recover.

What you'll need

- About 3 hours in total, spread out as you like
- Admin access to your own email, bank, router, and social accounts
- A phone with an authenticator or text-message capability

Links in this kit go only to official vendor or government help pages. We earn nothing from any of them.

2. The one-page security checklist

Print this page. Tick what is already true. Anything unticked is your to-do list.

Passwords and logins

- [ ] Every account has its own long, unique password
- [ ] A password manager stores them
- [ ] Nobody shares one login
- [ ] Two-step login is on for business email
- [ ] Two-step login is on for bank and payment accounts
- [ ] Two-step login is on for social media
- [ ] Former staff accounts are removed

Devices and data

- [ ] Computers and phones update automatically
- [ ] Devices lock with a PIN or password
- [ ] No unsupported (very old) systems in use
- [ ] Files are backed up automatically
- [ ] A restore has been tested in the last 6 months
- [ ] Router admin password has been changed
- [ ] Guests use a separate Wi-Fi network

Email and scams

- [ ] Staff know the 8 scam signs (Section 3)
- [ ] Nobody clicks links in unexpected messages
- [ ] Invoices are checked against known details
- [ ] Your email domain has SPF, DKIM, and DMARC set up

Money and people

- [ ] Two people approve any change to payment details
- [ ] A written plan exists for what to do if something goes wrong (Section 11)
- [ ] Staff have seen the 5 habits (Section 10)
- [ ] Bank and IT contacts are written down

Score yourself: 20 to 22 ticks is strong. 14 to 19 means a few quick wins. Under 14 means start with passwords, two-step login, and backups this week.

Want us to review your answers and grade your setup? The Security Scorecard ($79) is at https://collarcitytechhelp.com.

3. Spot the scam: 8 warning signs

Scams that hit small businesses are usually phishing emails, fake invoices, and fake requests to change where money is sent. Look for these signs. Two or more means stop and verify.

1. **Pressure and urgency.** "Pay today or service ends." Real vendors give time.
2. **A change in how to pay.** New bank details, a new payment link, or a request for gift cards.
3. **A sender address that is slightly off.** accounts@acmesupp1y.com instead of acmesupply.com.
4. **An unexpected attachment or login link.** Especially "view invoice" or "shared document".
5. **Generic greetings.** "Dear customer" from a company that knows your name.
6. **A request for a password, code, or account number.** No real company asks for these by email.
7. **Odd wording or an unusual request from the boss.** "Are you at your desk? I need a favor, keep this quiet."
8. **It feels too good, too scary, or too rushed.** That feeling is the sign.

Made-up examples

Fake invoice. From: billing@riverside-supply.example
Subject: Overdue invoice 4471, pay within 24 hours
"Our bank details have changed. Please send the payment to the new account below to avoid a late fee."
Signs: urgency, changed bank details, lookalike address (a capital I instead of an l).

Fake password reset. Subject: Your email will be deactivated
"Confirm your password within 12 hours using the link below."
Signs: threat, link, asks for a password.

Fake payment-change request. A message that appears to come from your landlord: "We've switched banks. Use these new details for rent starting this month."
Signs: payment detail change by email only. Call the number you already have on file before paying.

What to do

Don't click. Don't reply. Look up the real phone number yourself (not the one in the message) and call. Forward suspicious mail to your IT provider, then delete it. Report scams at reportfraud.ftc.gov.

4. Set up a password manager

A password manager creates and remembers a different strong password for every account. You remember one strong "master" password. This single change prevents the most common way accounts get taken over: reusing the same password everywhere.

Option A: Bitwarden (free tier, works on any device)

1. Go to bitwarden.com/help/getting-started-webvault and follow the official setup guide to create your account.
2. Choose a master password of 4 or more random words, such as "copper-lantern-seven-orchard". Write it on paper and keep it somewhere safe at first. Never store it in your email.
3. Install the browser extension and the phone app from the official Bitwarden pages.
4. Turn on two-step login for your Bitwarden account itself.
5. Log in to your most important accounts one at a time (email first, then bank). Let Bitwarden suggest a new password and save it.

Option B: Apple Passwords (built into iPhone, iPad, and Mac)

1. On an iPhone or iPad, open Settings and tap Passwords. On a Mac, open the Passwords app (or System Settings, Passwords).
2. Make sure iCloud Keychain is on, so passwords are saved across your Apple devices.
3. When you create or change a password, accept "Use Strong Password" when offered.
4. Open Passwords and check the security recommendations for reused or weak passwords.
5. Official help: support.apple.com (search "Passwords app").

Do these first: business email, bank and payment accounts, your domain or website account, and social media. Fix the top 5 this week and the rest over a month.
For staff: give each person their own login. Never share one.

General guidance: cisa.gov/secure-our-world/use-strong-passwords

5. Turn on two-step login

Two-step login (also called multi-factor authentication or MFA) asks for a second proof, such as a code from an app, when you sign in. Even if a thief learns your password, they can't get in. Use an authenticator app when you can; text messages are better than nothing.

Do it in this order

Account	Official help page
Gmail / Google Workspace	support.google.com/accounts/answer/185839
Microsoft 365 / Outlook	Microsoft: what is multifactor authentication
Your bank and payment apps	Open your bank's own website or app, find Security settings, and turn on two-step login. If you can't find it, call the number on your bank card.
Facebook	facebook.com/help/148233965247823
Instagram	help.instagram.com/566810106808145
General guide	cisa.gov/secure-our-world/turn-mfa

Tips

- Save the backup codes the service gives you. Print them and keep them somewhere safe, away from your computer.
- Never read a code to someone who calls or messages you. That is a scam.
- If you change phones, move your authenticator app first.
- Do email first. Whoever controls your email can reset every other password.

Tick it off: ☐ Email ☐ Bank ☐ Payment app ☐ Facebook ☐ Instagram ☐ Website/domain account

6. Backup plan template

A backup is the difference between a bad day and a business-ending one. Use the 3-2-1 idea: 3 copies, on 2 kinds of storage, with 1 copy somewhere else.

Fill this in

What to back up	Where it lives now	Backed up to	How often	Who checks
Customer records / client files				
Accounting / invoices				
Email and contacts				
Website and photos				
Phones				

Good choices

- **Cloud backup:** automatic and offsite. Use the backup feature of your existing cloud service (Google Drive, OneDrive, iCloud) or a business backup service.
- **External drive:** a second copy you disconnect after backing up, so ransomware can't reach it.

Test a restore (do this twice a year)

1. Pick 3 files at random.
2. Restore them from the backup to a different folder.
3. Open them. Do they work?
4. Write the date and result below.

Date tested: _____ Worked? ☐ Yes ☐ No Fixed by: _____

> A backup you have never tested is a hope, not a backup. Also keep one copy that is not always connected to your computer.

7. Wi-Fi basics

Your router is the front door to your office network. Most are never touched after setup. Ten minutes fixes the biggest problems.

Change the router's admin password

1. Find the router's sign-in address and login on the sticker on the router, or in the manual. Common addresses include 192.168.0.1 and 192.168.1.1.
2. Sign in from a computer connected to that router.
3. Find Administration, System, or Security settings and change the admin password to a long unique one. Save it in your password manager.
4. Change the Wi-Fi network password to something long. Use a passphrase of 4 or more words.

Set up a separate guest network

1. In the router settings, find "Guest network" (sometimes "Guest Wi-Fi").
2. Turn it on, give it a clear name like "YourShop-Guest", and set its own password.
3. Make sure "access to local network" or "allow guests to see each other" is OFF if the option exists.
4. Give customers only the guest password. Work devices, registers, and printers stay on the main network.

More quick wins

- Turn on automatic firmware updates if the router offers them, or check for updates twice a year.
- Use WPA2 or WPA3 security. Avoid WEP or "open".
- Turn off remote administration unless you need it.
- If your router is more than 7 to 8 years old or no longer gets updates, replace it.

Your internet provider's support page for your router model has exact steps.

8. Payment safety rule

> **The two-person rule:** no change to payment details, bank accounts, or payee information happens without two people approving it, and one of them confirms by phone using a number already on file.

Most costly small-business scams are not technical. Someone convinces a team member to send money somewhere new. The rule below stops almost all of them.

The rule, step by step

1. Any request to change bank details, send a payment to a new account, buy gift cards, or pay a rush invoice is a "payment change".
2. The person who receives the request does not act on it. They pass it to a second person.
3. The second person calls the vendor, landlord, or boss using a phone number from before the request. Never use a number or link in the message.
4. Only after the call, both people approve in writing (a short reply or a note in the shared log).
5. Keep a simple log: date, who asked, who verified, who approved.

If you are a one-person business

Use a "wait and verify" rule: no payment change on the same day it is requested, and always call a number you already have. Ask a trusted friend, your accountant, or your bookkeeper to be your second approver.

Write it down

Our payment approvers are: _____ and _____
The log is kept: _____

9. Twenty AI prompts for small business

Copy a prompt into the AI tool you use (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, or similar). Replace the [brackets] with your details.

> **Check before you send.** AI makes mistakes and can invent facts. Read every word. Check names, prices, dates, and claims. Never paste passwords, card numbers, or private customer details into an AI tool. Don't send legal, medical, or financial wording without a professional's review.

1. Reply to a positive review
Write a warm, short reply (under 60 words) to this Google review for my [type of business]: [paste review]. Thank them by name and mention one specific thing they said. Sound friendly and natural.

2. Reply to a negative review
Write a calm, professional reply to this negative review of my [type of business]: [paste review]. Thank them, acknowledge the issue without arguing or admitting legal fault, and invite them to contact me at [email or phone] to make it right. Under 80 words.

3. Google Business post
Write a Google Business Profile post under 150 words about [special, event, or news]. Friendly tone, one clear call to action, no hashtags.

4. Week of social posts
Write 5 short social media posts for my [type of business] in [town]. Topics: [list]. Tone: [friendly/professional/playful]. Do not invent prices, events, or awards. Mark anything I need to fill in with [brackets].

5. Caption for a photo
Write 3 caption options for a photo of [describe photo]. Under 40 words each. Add 3 relevant hashtags.

6. FAQ page
Write a customer FAQ with 8 questions and short answers for my [type of business]. Use these facts only: [hours, prices, policies]. Leave [brackets] where information is missing.

7. Menu or service descriptions
Rewrite these item descriptions to sound appetizing and clear, in under 20 words each: [paste items]. Don't add ingredients or claims I haven't given you.

Prompts, continued

8. Polite late-payment reminder (first)
Write a friendly first reminder email for an invoice of $[amount] that was due on [date] for [service]. Assume it was an oversight. Under 90 words. Include how to pay: [method].

9. Firm late-payment reminder (second)
Write a polite but firm second reminder for invoice [number] for $[amount], now [number] days overdue. Mention the payment options and ask them to reply by [date]. No threats.

10. Thank-you email to a new customer
Write a short thank-you email to a new customer of my [type of business]. Include what to expect next and how to reach me. Under 100 words.

11. Appointment reminder
Write a friendly appointment reminder text (under 40 words) with [date], [time], address placeholder, and how to reschedule.

12. Job posting
Write a clear job posting for a [role] at my [type of business] in [town]. Include duties, hours, and pay of [pay], and a simple way to apply. Keep it to 200 words.

13. Staff schedule message
Write a short, kind message to staff announcing the schedule change: [details]. Ask them to confirm by [date].

14. Newsletter
Write a 150-word customer newsletter for [month] with these items: [list]. Warm and brief. One call to action at the end.

Prompts, continued

> **15. Holiday hours notice**
> Write a short notice about our holiday hours: [hours]. Friendly and clear, for a sign, a social post, and an email (three versions).

> **16. Complaint response**
> A customer is upset about: [describe]. Write a calm reply that listens, apologizes for the experience (without admitting legal fault), and offers to talk by phone. Under 100 words.

> **17. Simple policy**
> Draft a plain-English one-page policy for [topic, like returns or cancellations] for my [type of business]. Keep it fair and clear. I'll have it reviewed before using it.

> **18. Meeting notes to action list**
> Turn these notes into a short action list with owner and due date for each item: [paste notes]. Mark unclear items with a question.

> **19. Explain a tech problem**
> Explain this tech problem in simple steps a non-technical person can follow: [describe problem]. Tell me what to check first and when to call a professional.

> **20. Scam check**
> Here is a message I received: [paste with names and numbers removed]. List any warning signs of a scam and tell me what I should do before replying.

Make any prompt better

- Say who it's for and what you want them to do.
- Give the facts yourself. The AI should not guess them.
- Ask for a shorter or friendlier version if it isn't right.
- Always edit in your own voice.

10. Staff one-pager: 5 security habits

Print this page and post it near the computers. These five habits stop most problems.

1	**Pause before you click.** Unexpected link, attachment, or urgent message? Stop and check with a real call or in person.
2	**Unique passwords, two-step login on.** Use the password manager. Never share a login or tell anyone a code.
3	**Money changes need two people.** New bank details or a rush payment request? Call a known number first.
4	**Update and lock.** Accept updates. Lock your screen when you step away. Keep work on work devices.
5	**Speak up fast.** Clicked something odd? Tell your manager right away. Nobody gets in trouble for reporting.

If something looks wrong, contact:
Manager: _____
IT provider: _____
Bank fraud line: _____

11. If something goes wrong

Don't panic, and don't hide it. Speed matters. Work through these steps in order.

First hour

1. **Stop the damage.** Disconnect the affected computer from Wi-Fi and the network cable. Don't turn it off yet if you can avoid it.
2. **Use a safe device.** From a different, trusted phone or computer, change the password of your email first, then your bank and other key accounts. Turn on two-step login.
3. **Call your bank.** If money moved or you shared payment details, call the number on the back of your card or on your bank's website. Ask them to stop or recall payments and to watch the accounts.
4. **Call your IT provider** (if you have one) or a trusted professional.
5. **Write down what happened.** Dates, times, what you clicked, messages received. Take screenshots.

Within a day

1. Report to the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center if money or data was taken: ic3.gov.
2. Report scams to the FTC: reportfraud.ftc.gov.
3. Warn affected customers or partners honestly and promptly. If customer data may have been exposed, talk to a professional about notification rules in your state.
4. Check your backups before restoring anything. Restore from a copy made before the problem started.
5. Look for forwarding rules or unknown devices in your email settings.

Contacts to fill in now:
Bank fraud line: _____
IT provider: _____
Insurance (if cyber cover): _____
Lawyer or advisor: _____

Guidance: ftc.gov small business cybersecurity and cisa.gov/secure-our-world

12. Next steps and disclosure

Your 7-day plan

Day	Do this
Day 1	Print the checklist (Section 2). Tick what you already do.
Day 2	Set up the password manager (Section 4). Do email and bank first.
Day 3	Turn on two-step login (Section 5).
Day 4	Set up backups and test a restore (Section 6).
Day 5	Router and guest Wi-Fi (Section 7).
Day 6	Agree the two-person payment rule (Section 8) and brief your team (Section 10).
Day 7	Pick two AI prompts from Section 9 and use them this week.

Want a second pair of eyes?

The **Security Scorecard** ($79) grades your setup from your answers and a public check of your email domain records, with a fix list and 30-day plan. **Done-for-you Online Presence** ($99/month) gives you a month of posts and review replies, ready to paste. Details: https://collarcitytechhelp.com

Disclosure

Designed and built by Alex using modern tools, including AI. Every project is personally reviewed before it goes live. We provide general guidance, not legal advice, and no service can guarantee you'll never be hacked.

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